Prayer for What

By Robert C. Reinhart

INTRODUCTION

There are a high number of homosexual priests and seminarians in the United States. How high is difficult to say. (Estimates range from 23 percent to 58 percent, with even higher percentages for younger priests.) That a high number of priests share a similar characteristic means that the church needs to consider both the challenges and the gifts offered by this group-- men who seek to serve God and the church with their whole selves. Prayer for What by Robert C. Reinhart

There she is again. Always that same awful black dress. I never see her at Mass or taking communion. Why does she come here? Lapsed Catholic? Too cold out? Crazy? It feels colder in here. I should go speak to her. No. If I leave her alone, she'll leave me alone.

She's lighting another candle. That's the third candle she's lit and I still haven't heard any money go into the box. Oh, God, she's turning around. Don't see me. You've lit your candle, lady, why don't you go home

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and give me a few minutes alone? I just want some peace and I can't even find it in my own church. Light another free candle. Be my guest.

Are you here because you've sinned, lady? Big sins? Little sins? Venial? Mortal? I'm tired of confessing. God, give me some new sins. Give poor Father Gilberti a break. I confess the same things every week, and he gives me the same advice and the same penance. "Bless me, father, for I am about to bore you to death. I have had frequent impure thoughts, had...accidents." What else can I call them?

What must Mrs. Cleary think? We playa game: It didn't happen and she doesn't know and I don't wash my sheets under cover of darkness. I'm the Phantom Laundryman, down in the laundry room at three in the morning, wondering if Father Gilberti can hear that damned old washing machine screaming away. I turn my Walkman up and pretend that old machine won't wake the dead. And I plug in that old iron and pray it won't blow the fuses again or electrocute me.

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And how would that saintly old man take hearing that I take the cross off my wall because I can't keep my eyes off it? Who sculpted that incredibly beautiful body?

You lied, Father Flynn. In the seminary you said this passed. "Once you're working eighteen hours a day in some parish, me boy, you'll go to bed too tired to even think of it," says he. "You'll see, me boy, there is no room for impure thoughts in exhausted minds." Wrong, Father Flynn, there's room for an army of them in there.

And when I told him I had "tendencies." "Tendencies?" says he. "Well-er, ah, em-tendencies, you say? Ah, *those* tendencies. Well, terrible as they are in the eyes of Christ, those...tendencies...won't keep you from serving your savior if you don't act on them. Shower alone, me boy. Shower alone." The road to salvation is flooded with cold water.

And the old fraud must have told George the same thing. "Shower, George, shower." No wonder they said George was crazy. Water on the brain. But he didn't

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look crazy when I found him. He looked exhausted. No, he looked as if he was pleading with me, as if he wanted me to help him. How could he do that to himself and then just sit there waiting to bleed to death?

I couldn't understand what I was seeing, and now I can't stop seeing it...over and over. How did he do that much damage with that dull knife? And that filthy blue rag in his mouth. Couldn't understand that for days. Of course he bit it to keep from screaming. Just sitting there on the stones in his blood and not saying a word, just trying to beat me off, just trying to get me to leave him the hell alone. Father Shay said it was God's will that I found him and I should thank God. I don't. I just don't want George to hate me for stopping him. What did they do with him? Doesn't matter. Now he's no good to God or man.

She's lighting another candle and I still didn't hear any money go in the box. I really should speak to her. Oh, to hell with it. Go ahead, light them all, lady.

What keeps me here? God help me, I don't give a damn about people. I only half listen to them. I tell them

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things I only half believe, but they look at me and they hope I do, because if I don't believe, what's left? Oh, yes, my child, there's hope in hopeless situations. There, there. It's God's will. Throw them a little something to keep terrible things from scaring them to death, to keep them from wanting to kill me for being a fraud. Can't be the cause of murderous thoughts in their hearts. That would be leading them into sin.

Confessions are the worst. How do I hear another confession from some poor man who's had sex with another man? "Your immortal soul is in grave danger. Say thirty 'Hail. Marys.'" No, say twenty-nine...we're having a special. How do I tell that man who lives with his lover that he must not touch his Edmund or sleep with him? Every week I tear another piece off him. He asks me why God sent him Edmund to love if it's a mortal sin? It is God's way of testing you and you must cease sinning. I want to tell him to stop coming to me before Edmund gets fed up and leaves him. And wouldn't that be a sin

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But I want to tell all the men to run, even that wretched man who tells me he lusts after little boys. I tell him to honor his marriage. I give him endless rosaries to say, just to keep him busy. Not busy enough. I tell all the married men to avoid the occasions of sin with other men and while I listen I want to know more, to have them whisper every detail through the grill.

And damn that man with the sexy voice. He does tell me everything. He talks so softly that I have to put my ear right against the grill and then I can feel his breath on my ear. He tells me he doesn't want to lose his soul, but he can't give up life, be celibate like me. I tell him to pray, to want a family, to want a woman. I dread his confessions because I want to know what he looks like. Sometimes I'm sure he's not a penitent, but some man who knows all about me and tells me these awful things because he knows. And when I'm alone, I imagine he confesses to me, because he wants me.

Someday one of them will say, "You don't believe any of this, why should 17"

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God! I come here to be alone to think, but I can't stand what I think.

I must stop this. Keep your eye on that woman. Think about what brings her here, keeps her lighting all those candles? They aren't free, lady. But maybe her soul is seeping out of her or she comes here to hide, so IT-that big IT won't get her. God help me, lady, I should care about you, but I don't.

Well, I can't stay here forever. I'm stiff and it's damned cold in here. Get moving, Francis. Mrs. Cleary will give you hell if you're late for dinner again. And that man's coming for instruction. We both know he's converting to please his fiancée, but I can't just tell him he's a liar, that he doesn't want faith. Oh, and there's that damned ladies' sodality meeting tonight.

I must tell Mrs. Cleary to put more bleach in the wash. The altar cloths look dingy. How long has it been since the brass has been polished or the marble shined? I can even see the dust on the grillwork over the stained glass from here. My God, what kind of world do we live in that forces us to put stained glass in cages? Dear God,

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where is people's respect for churches? Why in the world should churches have to protect themselves from people?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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